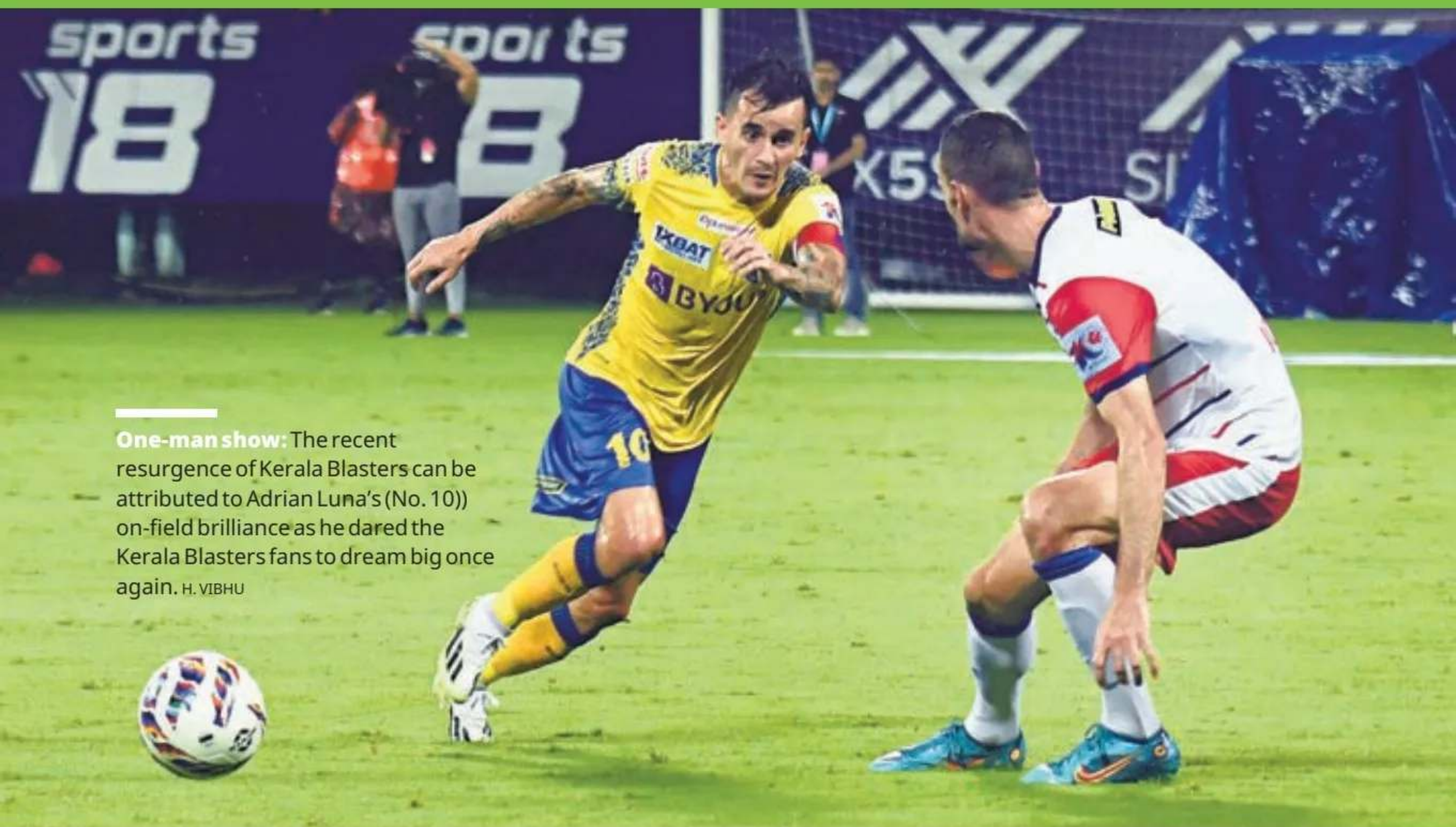




One-man show: The recent resurgence of Kerala Blasters can be attributed to Adrian Luna's (No. 10) on-field brilliance as he dared the Kerala Blasters fans to dream big once again. H. VIBHU

campaign," said the AIFF president, appearing to uphold East Bengal's complaint in this reference.

Amitabha Das Sharma

Luna love

In the past decade a couple of international players have managed to strike a chord with the Kerala Blasters faithfuls. Canadian Iain Hume, with his bald plate and boundless energy, was the first overseas star to make an impact with the Kochi crowd. Humettan, as he was called, left a lasting impression with the fans during his stay in Kochi.

However, after Hume, Kerala Blasters fans never had an overseas hero to look up to until Adrian Luna arrived in the 2021 season. The Uruguayan, with his sublime skills and scoring ability, quickly became the

toast of the Kochi crowd. The recent resurgence of the Kochi side could be attributed to his on-field brilliance as he dared the Kerala Blasters fans to dream big once again.

This season, the midfielder had seamlessly slipped into his role of influential creator as Kerala Blasters probably enjoyed its best start. However, Luna picked up an injury during training, which was initially thought to be minor one. But after undergoing surgery, it dawned on everyone that he would be unavailable for the rest of the season.

On Christmas eve, when Kerala Blasters played Mumbai City, the crowd at the Jawaharlal Nehru stadium was the biggest of the season. The Manjappada expressed their support and admiration for Luna by unveiling a massive tifo that read

'Recharge Luna We await your Magic'.

The Uruguayan appreciated the act of the fans and, in an emotional post on *Instagram*, paid tribute to the yellow loyalists. He said he could feel the atmosphere in the stadium while being in Mexico.

"Thank you guys, this means a lot. This motivates me to come back stronger than before. It was great to see boys giving out everything on the pitch and getting that deserved victory against MCFC.

The atmosphere in the stadium was electric. I could feel that from Mexico. Can't wait to be back, see you all." said Luna in post.

It seems, his team has coped to live without his absence as Kerala Blasters posted an impressive win to keep its home record intact.

M. R. Praveen Chandran



« "Clubs have submitted hard evidence in the form of videos to back their claims (of inconsistent refereeing). As officials and administrators, we have to work towards minimising these mistakes. We cannot hide behind the mask of the 'acceptable 15 per cent human error norm'. — Kalyan Chaubey, AIFF President »